

Sea Turtle Conservation Curacao

Photography, Videography, & Lighting Guidelines

April, 2026 - Version 1, compiled by Russ Gooding, with Ingo van Veghel and Reggie De Santis.

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Board Approved and Effective: __April__ / __13__ / __2026__ (and addendum concerning applicability to all STCC Members requested; see page 8)

Images captured prior to the approval of this document are grandfathered, and will remain in the STCC archives. Great care, and appropriate disclaimers, should be taken if older, out of compliance, images are utilized after the effective date. No outdated photos or videos should be utilized in current STCC training materials except to demonstrate counter-examples to current standards. This means that all educational materials should be updated using new images, still or video, as soon as practicable, certainly within one year of adopting these guidelines.

STCC: Please use your image makers for the good of the organization.

Context: These Photography, Videography, & Lighting Guidelines* were first discussed in late 2025, in direct response to three rousing conversations regarding ethics/standards as they impact image making under the domain of a professional, national conservation organization. Conversation one centered on “hero” shots of volunteers and guests holding turtles up for portraits - proof of participation; these images were made over and over during the course of field research, particularly during netting sessions. Conversation two targeted the use of a non-local (Pacific) Hawksbill image in conjunction with a collaborative social media post about a local, Curacao, Hawksbill nest. Conversation three focused on a one-time incident (or opportunity, depending on perspective) when an STCC event photographer took a brief photo series of a mesmerized young boy cupping the gloved hand of a PhD researcher, who held a live - and endangered - Hawksbill hatchling in her palm. The three conversations provoked several volunteers, photographers and others, to begin researching the standards that other professional conservation and wildlife oriented organizations use to guide their image makers, their staff, their volunteers and guests, their vetted professionals, and the publicists, including STCC’s Social Media and Education Committees, who choose (or request) images for use in across social media accounts, in press releases, in educational materials, and all other forms of visual outreach. It is agreed that the images we project as an organization are often the first and most lasting impression that any outsider, be they an island resident, a tourist, a local politician, or a international change maker, will perceive and internalize. Our shared images, more than the depth of our words or the breadth of our members’ bonafide good actions, build or erode STCC’s public reputation - and frequently these are searchable images which become part of the permanent public record of our organization’s involvement with the world. Further, the manner in which our team photographers behave while collecting images, and the manner in which STCC’s non-photographer participants interact with the photographers and the public, also colors the immediate perception of anyone attending events in person. We must not merely act professionally; we must be professional in all our actions.

Hat Tips: What follows is a largely derivative document, heavily influenced by the ethical standards and practical guidelines set forth by numerous conservation, wildlife, and photography groups, including but not limited to: International League of Conservation Photographers; Audubon; U.S. Fish & Wildlife Service; Raincoast; Nature Photographers Network; Nature TTL; Jane Goodall Institute; The Coral Reef Alliance. I've also had the pleasure of conferring directly with several international turtle conservationists. Reggie De Santis, the passionate turtle biologist behind Global Fauna, was the first outsider to review the document and she suggested adding both a Drone Policy and a Field Summary; thanks Reggie! Dr. Karen Eckert of WIDECAST offered her encouragement and a hope that STCC's efforts might lead to harmonized guidelines across many turtle conservation organizations. Internal to STCC, our Field Assistant Emeritus, Ingo van Veghel, was active in many ethical conversations leading to the creation of this document, and he reviewed the earliest draft, adding substantially to the project. Nearly two years of working as an event photographer for STCC has exposed me to many specific situations which in their turn are addressed point by point within these guidelines. Thanks to all the organizations and individuals who, passively or actively, invested their time in this project!

STCC's Photography, Videography, & Lighting Guidelines strive to align in fact and in spirit with the STCC Scientific Committee Code of Ethics, here:

Sea Turtle Conservation Curacao is committed to protect our island's resident and migratory sea turtles, conserving vital nesting and feeding habitats, and ensuring the safety and well being of our staff and volunteers. We conduct rigorous scientific research on sea turtle health, nesting success, population trends, and migration, while educating and engaging local communities and visitors in conservation and responsible environmental stewardship. We are committed to scientific integrity, ethical research practices, and transparency in all aspects of our work.

STCC Photography, Videography, & Lighting Guidelines

Do No Harm. This is the foundational guideline for STCC image makers. No photo or video will be made, the creation of which negatively impacts the sea turtles or their environment which we are bound to protect. Implications of this rule are significant and will immediately alter the photographic standards of the organization. No Harm to turtles means no added stress during the already stressful span of time when they are captured and removed from their natural environment for legitimate research purposes, e.g., turtles may not be slow walked from the holding station to the release point in order to facilitate turtle/human portraits. No Harm entails not approaching turtles in their natural habitat so closely that their behavior is modified, that a flight response is provoked; use good, practiced, judgement - a diver can often approach a resting turtle more closely than a feeding turtle; sometimes a curious turtle will approach a diver - make use of fortuitous opportunities, without instigating over-close turtle encounters; never chase a turtle. **If a turtle exhibits stress that is attributable to the photographer, as opposed to the researchers/rescuers and the event in progress (data collection, hook removal, etc.), the photographer should immediately disengage and back away slowly. It is the image maker's responsibility to NOT impinge on research and rescue efforts, but to document efforts from a safe distance, out of the way. Photograph the work; don't make the workers work around the photographer.**

Follow The Law. Sea Turtles, species to species, are all either threatened or endangered. It is the responsibility of STCC to follow the law, nationally and internationally, with regard to sea

turtle interactions, and that includes image making in the course of data collection and documentary efforts. When in doubt, inquire with the STCC Scientific Committee.

Data Collection and Documentation. This two-part role provides the primary drive for recording images. The STCC image makers' role is to bolster measurable data with supporting imagery, and to document the efforts of STCC's staff and volunteers across the entire spectrum of their duties, from research, rescue, and rehabilitation, to strandings, strikes, and necropsies, to beach patrols, health checks, nest excavations, and even building maintenance at the Rescue Center. Yes, it's nice when volunteers are recognized for their efforts, having been caught in action by the photographers. However, as discussed below, there will be no more posed shots of staff or volunteers interacting with turtles - only legitimate, documentary, images that capture unfolding events. The Scientific and Data Committees will transmit standards, and conduct training, regarding specific data collection images that are needed for turtle event reports, e.g., pictures of FP tumors with a ruler included for scale or photos for facial recognition. Facial recognition images will be taken directly by researchers and immediately uploaded to EarthRanger; facial recognition photos captured during research sessions are not the responsibility of STCC's photographers and videographers.

Photographic Responsibility & General Oversight. STCC affiliated image makers work under the aegis of the STCC Scientific Committee which has been established by the STCC Board. The Scientific Committee is responsible for vetting volunteer image makers, at the outset and across the duration of their affiliation with STCC. Image makers' primary roles, noted above, are the purview of the Scientific Committee. Image makers report to the Scientific Committee and respond to requests from the Scientific Committee. Assuming no perceived conflicts, and keeping the Scientific Committee informed, image makers are encouraged to work directly with other Committees, staff, or volunteers to gather photos or videos necessary for the work of those committees or individuals or to document their roles within STCC.

See Appendix V - **Vetted STCC Image Makers** - for additional details

Duty. The duty of each STCC affiliated photographer and videographer is to capture as many good images as possible whenever they operate under the STCC aegis. What the image makers choose to capture is their choice - their perception, their gear, their capabilities; of course good photographers will encourage the team of staff, volunteers and guests around them to point out interesting perspectives and opportunities (it's amazing how staring through a lens enforces tunnel vision that elides the rest of the world's unfolding). Good images are not the same as approved images. It is possible that a photographer will capture, accidentally or intentionally, misdeeds, errors, and faux pas, or that a photographer will violate these guidelines. It is possible that the photographer's judgement will be questioned by other STCC staff, volunteers, or guests. It is the affirmed policy of STCC to allow the image makers, so long as they operate in good faith within the bounds of these guidelines, to operate freely while recording images. Any disagreements or disputes about the content of the recorded images or the circumstances of the image making should be brought up with the STCC Scientific Committee and/or the STCC Board - after the event. The Board affirms the right of each photographer to exercise their own judgement in carrying out their duty; by implication, no staff member, volunteer, or guest will publicly dispute an image maker's right to capture or record events. All disputes will be handled internally, in part so that our organization presents a unified front to the watchful public during events. There's always room for improvement and continued discussions will lead, incrementally, to sound best practices.

No Regularly Posed Images. STCC, and the photographer drafting these protocols, has been guilty of encouraging volunteers to hold up turtles, typically while walking from the holding

station to the sea, for the “proof of participation” turtle/human portraits. No more. STCC photographers are encouraged to take documentary photos of events in progress, including the release of turtles after data collection or hook removal, however the photographers will no longer encourage “hero” shots and will only collect images that opportunity affords. This does not preclude the photographer from using his or her own judgement and taking advantage of fleeting opportunities to capture pictures of staff, volunteers, guests, and vetted professionals interacting directly or indirectly with sea turtles. “Hold that position!” is a lot different than “please walk to this point, stop, turn, lift the turtle and smile!”

No Turtle Selfies. Corollary to the No Posed Images guideline, STCC is following international standards in wildlife and conservation photography/videography by explicitly banning selfies with turtles. Don’t do it. This rule applies to all STCC members: image makers, staff, volunteers, and vetted professionals.

No “Cute” Turtles. Sea turtles are wild animals. Humans, especially the trained staff, volunteers, and vetted professionals who regularly and legitimately interact with the turtles, should never engage in activities that portray these wild animals as cute, as pets, as capable of domestication, etc. Turtles should not be cuddled, petted, hand fed, or in any way treated like anything other than a wild creature caught up in a fleeting moment of captivity (nominally for the benefit of the individual or the species). Normalizing interactions between humans and sea turtles inadvertently recalibrates the public to accept - even to desire - turtle interactions. Professional interactions should be minimal, intentional, assistive or research based, and done.

Questionable Images. Not sure if that image you captured is in line with these guidelines? Ask. Questionable images, or images captured in questionable circumstances, will be reviewed by either or both the STCC Scientific Committee and the STCC Board before release. Image makers: ask for permission, not forgiveness. We have lawyers on our team, and they, among other wise voices, will offer good counsel.

Personal Protective Equipment Will Be Worn. All staff, trained volunteers, guest volunteers, and vetted professionals will wear personal protective equipment - GLOVES - when interacting directly with turtles or turtle nests. PPE Gloves will always be disposable (medical latex or nitrile) gloves, excepting ONLY that “work” gloves can be worn during in-water efforts, such as during a netting session or a turtle catch (free diving or SCUBA). Anyone not wearing gloves during turtle interactions or potential interactions will be removed from the event until they are wearing gloves. Any photos portraying staff or volunteers without proper PPE interacting with turtles will not be utilized for any publicly facing media, but may be used to train or retrain volunteers. Image makers do not need to wear gloves while operating their cameras, however they must ask a gloved individual to participate if a turtle contact is necessary, e.g., moving a deceased hatching out of shadows into the light, or shifting the position of a turtle or part of a turtle during a necropsy to facilitate a higher quality image.

Please see the PPE Explainer at the end of this document - Appendix III - for more details.

Turtle Massage. This activity merits its own guideline. Massaging the turtle’s neck, applying pressure might be a better description, during high stress events like data collection, hook removal, or transportation has anecdotal support among practitioners; the practice can calm a stressed turtle. However, images of volunteers massaging turtles encourages the public to do the same, i.e., to attempt to reach out and touch wild turtles. Images of turtle massage may be taken, but they are only to be used in-house as visual aids for volunteer training; they are not to be disseminated publicly through STCC channels or through the image maker’s channels.

No Reenactments. Use multiple photographers/videographers, multiple angles, but do not engage in reenactment for the benefit of capturing images of live turtles. For example, if the authorized measuring teams have logged all the data necessary (or available) to create an EarthRanger entry event, there is NO excuse for having the measurements repeated by another group, particularly a group of guests, so that a photographer or videographer or producer can capture their preferred people performing unnecessary tasks. If, for example, a supervisory Lead needs to repeat a measurement to confirm it, that is an entirely different matter. This rule only applies to repeat performances of human/turtle interactions for the explicit purpose of alternate image capture. The educational exception: Staff or other STCC Leads may request specific images be taken and re-taken for the express and limited purpose of developing training and/or educational material. Sometimes it takes several shots of team members collecting a Straight Carapace Length to capture the image the training materials demand. We acknowledge that proper training benefits the turtles at a species level, so creating reliable training materials is an essential task and one that allows brief extensions of the time a live turtle is kept from its natural environment. The educational exception must be narrowly interpreted, not used as an excuse to violate the guideline, especially by outside image makers.

No Baiting/Feeding. No baiting or feeding of wild turtles in the wild. This guideline is obvious, but it's packed all around with gray space. Yes, it is legitimate to photograph ILLEGAL turtle feedings, but only if it is made clear in captions and other documentation that the images demonstrate a reprehensible practice, one tourists should avoid (and government should act against). Do not take photos of turtles feeding on fish remains from the spectacle/performance - even after the fact of the turtle feeding spectacle - unless the fish remains are documented and captioned as an unnatural and opportunistic food source available because of illegal activity. Yes, it is legitimate to photograph turtles being fed in captivity during rehabilitation after Sargassum rescues, or post surgery, or after comparable impacts. All images of captive-fed turtles should include a text disclaimer. See the sample disclaimers in Appendix I.

No Long-Term Captive Turtle Images. Except for stories and editorial images leading up to the release of the captive(s), or turtles captive due to rescue or rehabilitation efforts, the organization should not make use of captive turtles in image making. In other words, Aquarium or Farm kept specimens should never be used to represent wild turtles; put in the effort to photograph wild turtles. Any photos of turtles taken in captivity must be clearly captioned as such. See the example disclaimers in Appendix I.

Maintain Safe Distance. The image maker should keep themselves and their camera's lens as far from the turtle as possible in order to reduce the stress on the turtle, particularly during already stressful research or rescue situations. Image makers must also protect themselves during fast paced event photography. Turtles do bite. Image makers must understand that safety, and digit retention, means you must keep clear of the turtle's jaws; some turtles are naturally more aggressive (Loggerheads), but all turtles when provoked to flight or fight responses can and will bite. Use a longer focal length whenever practical to avoid close lens close-ups of stressed turtles; amazing close ups can be taken from a safe distance with a 70-200mm lens. Data collection, in particular FP tumor measurements, shark bites, or propeller impacts, may justify closer photos with macro or close focus wide angle lenses. Be judicious.

No Flash. Flash photography, even subtle fill flash pops on small underwater cameras like the OM-7, are not permitted because flashes startle turtles, increasing stress and provoking flight responses during data collection, hook removals, etc. Flash photography of sea turtles is illegal in some jurisdictions.

Limited Lighting. Continuous white light, or red light at night, is permitted to generate contrast or in lieu of fill flash, but must be limited to the minimum necessary - and must be immediately discontinued if the turtle(s) show discomfort (stress or flight response) or “positive” distraction (moving towards the light, in any instance except when an intentional moon replication is used to draw hatchlings into the sea).

Red Light Considerations. Red light is generally recognized as safe light at night for staff and volunteers performing nesting watches, monitoring for naturally emergent hatchings, or assisting with hatchling releases after nest excavations. However, it is obvious that hatchlings do respond “positively” to bright red light, that is to say the hatchlings are attracted toward the light, as though towards the moon. During STCC hatchling releases, any large (e.g., Lume Cube XL) red light must be held by a photographer’s assistant who carefully backs toward the sea ahead of the scrambling hatchlings, then stands in the sea as the hatchlings swarm from shore, down the runway, and into the water. Large/bright red lights should be avoided entirely during naturally emergent hatchings.

Habitat Protection. It is imperative that we protect the turtles’ environment at two levels. First, STCC image makers will not alter the natural environment to ‘get the shot.’ Second, in certain circumstances, and in consultation with the STCC Scientific Committee and the STCC Board, we may necessarily refrain from identifying the location where an image was taken. If, for instance, STCC staff relocated a nest from a heavily trafficked tourist beach to a remote shore, it is in the best interest of those eggs if we don’t disclose the whereabouts of the new nest. Not every detail must be shared every time. The safety of the turtles must hold sway. Ultimately, we are interlopers in the wild spaces and we are obliged to treat the inhabitants and their habitat as perfectly, as humanely, as possible. Leave No Trace.

Obligation To Report. On Curacao, it is the clearly stated obligation of every STCC staff member and volunteer to report turtle events immediately and directly (the staff or lead responsibility), or through their team Lead or a staff member (the general volunteer responsibility), to the STCC Photographers WhatsApp chat, or to the public Patrols app if contact cannot be promptly made with one or more photographers. The photographers must be notified promptly any time that a turtle “event” is in progress. Turtle events are defined elsewhere by the Scientific Committee, but generally and minimally include any turtle interaction which warrants inclusion in EarthRanger, thus: STCC netted or hand caught turtles, injured or fisher netted/captured turtles, boat strikes, strandings, poaching/mutilation, nesting, hatchings, etc. If there is any doubt, reach out.

On Klein Curacao, if a dedicated photographer is not present during patrols, it is the obligation of the Lead or other responsible party to take documentary images by any means possible (phone, GoPro, camera).

Many turtle events are one-time incidents what will never be repeated. These incidents become part of the record of turtle events on Curacao and Klein Curacao. It is prudent to have professional images taken whenever possible and to store those images in the permanent archives of STCC to be utilized alongside other data in reports, in media presentations, as evidence in criminal proceedings, and so forth.

Photographers WhatsApp Chat. Immediately upon STCC Board approval of these guidelines, the Chair of the Scientific Committee will create a Photographers WhatsApp Chat group that will include, at minimum: all vetted STCC image makers; all staff members; all active interns; all Committee chairs; the Board President or designee; others as needed. This chat will be used to promptly alert STCC image makers to any turtle event in progress. Alerts should be made quickly enough to allow available image makers to respond in tandem with

other STCC team members so they can fully document each event. The Chair of the Scientific Committee and the Scientific Committee's Board Liaison shall hold administrative privileges for this chat; either of these individuals may designate one vetted image maker to act on their behalf in this role.

Permissions. The image makers operating under the STCC aegis trust that image capture permission has been granted by event attendees, to include staff, volunteers, vetted professionals, and guests. It is the responsibility of STCC to alert staff and volunteers to the fact that by participating in events they have expressly consented to having their image captured. It is suggested that STCC insert an implied consent statement within all staff and volunteer employment/acceptance contracts. Further, anyone participating in any STCC event should be required to sign a release from liability document (either annually for regulars, or episodically for visitors/guests) and this Liability Release form should include phrasing about implied consent for image capture. Field staff should re-iterate this fact of implied consent during any event briefings, as a reminder to members and as an notice to the the public. Anecdotally, one STCC photographer has taken the extra step of requesting, during briefings, that if participants don't want to be photographed, the participants should raise their hands to eye level and form the sign of the cross with their index fingers as a ward against image making. Photographers are notorious demons, and a well-crafted image will retain a small portion of the subject's soul. You have been warned.

See Appendix I - **Limited Child Imaging** - for further information on children under age 15.

Image Copyright and Attribution. Unless other written arrangements are made with image makers, the maker of the image holds the copyright, worldwide, for each of their images. It is incumbent upon STCC to always provide full attribution - photo credits - to photographers and videographers. Typically this will include the image maker's self-applied watermark on the images (which shall be retained or re-applied when formatting for social media or any other use), and it will include preferably, a collaboration request, or acceptably, a hot-link tag, on Instagram, LinkedIn, or other media. Image makers will be credited wherever appropriate, to include an acknowledgment in press releases, training materials, and academic papers.

Image Ownership and Usage. Photographers operating alongside STCC as volunteer members acknowledge that they could not obtain such unique images were it not for STCC allowing them to participate in turtle events. In return for this image making access, the photographers agree to share edited images with STCC, expecting no further compensation beyond full copyright credit each time an image is used. Actual ownership of the images remains with the photographer unless the image is explicitly purchased by or donated to STCC. This means that the photographers may use their images in any way that is not detrimental to STCC, i.e., on their own websites and social media accounts, or to illustrate articles, blogs, books, or other digital and printed materials. In specific instances, STCC's Scientific Committee may request that a photographer not privately publish images until after they have been used for a certain purpose within the organization, e.g., published on Social Media channels for maximum impact, or published within the context of a scientific paper to establish research primacy. Photographers wishing to remain affiliated with STCC will understand the merit of occasionally tamping their desire to publish images they have recorded. Corollary: STCC cannot request that images not be published without stating a specific reason/purpose, and a firm use-by date; there will be no indefinite holds on imagery. Image makers who wish to remain in good standing with STCC should never share, post, publish, or broadcast images that fail to meet the standards of these STCC Photography, Videography, & Lighting Guidelines. The goal is mutually beneficial collaboration.

Without prior written consent, STCC may not sell, license, or otherwise distribute donated images (those provided by vetted volunteer image makers) to any other organization, though they may authorize fully credited reposts on social media channels, e.g., via Global Fauna, The Turtleman Foundation, Turtle Eggsplorer, or similar venues. STCC may not authorize any subsidiary, subcontractor, or other affiliated partner to utilize the photographer's copyrighted images without the photographer's written consent, even if that secondary or subsequent use is not for profit.

STCC Image Makers - All Volunteers, Interns, Staff, & Qualified Professionals. All STCC members and their image making efforts fall under the domain of these Photography, Videography, & Lighting Guidelines. No exceptions. Each member should, at minimum, be familiarized with the *Quick Image Making Field Rules* outlined in Appendix VI during STCC Volunteer Training or in the refresher training for established volunteers. While STCC will appoint certain individuals to photograph specific events, or to act as on-call photographers for unscheduled events, all members are expected to understand the basic "field" guidelines and apply them if they're at an STCC event and have a camera or other digital image recording device with them. If you're snapping the most casual pictures of turtles on your phone and you're an STCC volunteer, the STCC Board expects that you'll understand and align your efforts with these common sense, conservation oriented, guidelines. STCC asks image makers who have captured beautiful images to share them on the STCC Socials and Patrols WhatsApp chats. Do understand, all volunteer images taken during STCC events and shared with STCC may be used by the organization in creating social media, educational, or other posts and visual products; all images will be properly credited; no other compensation will be awarded. Please see Appendix V for detailed notes on STCC Vetted Image Makers.

No images, still or video, of any sick, injured, or dead turtle which were taken at an STCC facility or event may be shared by an STCC member without explicit permission from the STCC Board. Corollary to this: the STCC Board may request members remove unapproved images their personal accounts if those images were captured at any STCC facility or event. STCC members may be censured for posting unauthorized images, not limited to removing the individual from STCC WhatsApp chats or future events. STCC facilities include the organization's leased spaces, collaborative spaces provided by other organizations (e.g., Seaquarium), or temporary spaces utilized for care or storage (e.g., a veterinary clinic or the freezer space at CARMABI).

Non-STCC Professional/Influencer Image Makers. Professional (tv, web, publication, etc.) and/or "influencer" image makers who are not STCC volunteers or known affiliates must seek STCC Board permission to engage in any professional image making endeavors, not limited to social media accounts, websites, articles, blogs, television programming, or any other digital or print endeavors. The STCC Board will establish guidelines for interacting with outside image makers. Recommendations: STCC should create logo-credentials to be worn by authorized outside image makers during events; any Board member present at an event should be able to make impromptu judgement calls on whether to allow outside image makers to participate, if they download and accept these image making guidelines.

Casual Image Makers. Tourists and others present at turtle events will take pictures or videos. It is the role of STCC's photographers and other volunteers to educate the public, to encourage safe image capture, and to ensure that no-one is using flash, or white lights at night. Overwhelm them with kindness. Ask them to take two steps back, to give the turtles and the trained STCC members the space they need to function without added stress.

Raw Images, Total Images, Timeframe. The edited image collection an image maker shares with STCC is entirely up to their discretion. It is typical, for example, that a photographer will

supply 25-100 edited images to STCC after a morning-long turtle event. Photographers will not be asked to share RAW/DNG images as these are artistically “flat” and not fully rendered. Photographers typically share edited images as high resolution jpegs within 24-72 hours after the close of an event. Images may be shared over WhatsApp initially, but should be made available in full resolution to STCC via DropBox or other file sharing methods.

Transparency. Both the image maker and STCC are obliged to be transparent and brutally honest about the circumstances in which images were captured. There should never be overt misrepresentation, nor sly dissembling. For example, if a social media post addresses a local Hawksbill turtle event, do no use - or collaborate with another poster who uses - an image of a Pacific Hawksbill. Credibility takes years to earn, and a moment’s indiscretion to relinquish.

Minimal Editing Encourages Honesty. Edit sparingly: crop, remove dust, improve the white balance and contrast, perhaps gently mask the sky and shift the color temperature a few points off of “as shot,” but don’t eviscerate the image and attempt to rebuild it. It is the task of the photographer to take good images of actual events, and to render them beautifully with an editing program (the modern equivalent of a darkroom, with a host of rather comparable adjustments). Edits should never substantially alter the image or change the story it tells.

Image Storage. It is the responsibility of STCC to store the images that are shared with the organization. STCC’s volunteer image makers recommend at least a double back up - SSD and a Cloud Service. Ideally there should be duplicate SSDs held in separate locations and updated monthly, plus the Cloud Service. If STCC does not maintain an organized image collection within their database, it is explicitly not the responsibility of volunteer image makers to store, locate, or re-share images after they are originally passed to STCC. Respect for the image makers’ time demands STCC’s organizational responsibility for images. Google Drive is NOT an acceptable long-term cloud storage backup because the images remain attached to the image maker’s account and are not actually transmitted to the organization.

Liability. STCC can not be held liable for accidental damage, wear, loss, or theft of camera or lighting equipment used by volunteer or outside image makers during STCC turtle events. Hold your camera close.

STCC Committees. Any and all images deemed appropriate by the Scientific Committee will be available to the other STCC Committees for their use in promoting and documenting STCC activities. Other Committees may not publish images that will be used in future academic articles until those articles are published. Other Committees may request specific images from the STCC affiliated image makers.

Drone Policy. The use of drones (UAVs) during STCC events is prohibited unless explicitly authorized - in writing - by the STCC Scientific Committee and compliant with local aviation laws. Drones must never be flown in a way that disturbs nesting turtles, hatchlings, or research activities. On Curacao, drones must never be flown within 100 meters of flamingos. Drones may never be used when cross-training for rescues or conducting actual rescues if a helicopter is on the scene. When in doubt, don’t drone until you have secured permission from the STCC Scientific Committee. Drone use that is perceived as illegal under Curacao law will be promptly reported to the Coast Guard at #913.

Field Summary. Upon approval of these guidelines, Field Summary cards will be created and appended to any digital or printed collection of STCC Field Cards, ensuring that laminated copies are available at all research sessions.

See Appendix VI for the suggested text of “Quick Image Making Field Rules.”

Appendices

Appendix I - Additional Image Making Details

Exceptions and Disclaimers

Historical images, or contemporary images which contravene the basic guidelines listed above, must be accompanied by disclaimers that explain the exceptions to these Board approved standards. Adapt the example disclaimers as needed to suit the actual circumstances.

For human feeding and/or captivity of wild sea turtles:

STCC does not endorse feeding wild turtles, or keeping them captive. These Green Sea Turtles were rescued at Boka Ascension following a destructive Sargassum influx. The turtles are being rehabilitated and will be released as soon as the conditions on their native feeding grounds return to normal.

For images with trained volunteers or vetted professionals:

STCC does not endorse handling or direct interaction with Sea Turtles. These Green Sea Turtles have been captured as part of an approved research project and were promptly released [or...moved to a rehabilitation facility; or a veterinary facility; or our rescue center] per our Scientific Committees standards.

Limited Child Imaging

The STCC Board affirms that the *faces* of children WILL NOT BE PUBLISHED on any STCC channels, even with parental permission.

Minors age 15 and up may be photographed and have their images used, for example when Broadreach brings student groups to netting sessions. Image makers, please confirm age or simply avoid image capture of young people. It is suggested that Broadreach or other student guests who are under 15 be asked to wear something specific, perhaps an orange bandana, which will indicate that the image makers may not focus on them.

Child Imaging guidelines are subject to change at STCC Board discretion, and will likely be more restrictive, not less restrictive. Any exceptions or alterations to the Child Imaging guidelines may only be the result of STCC Board level policy changes.

Appendix II - Artificial Intelligence and Content Credentials

AI Generated Images

No photographer or videographer working for, or volunteering on behalf of, STCC shall create images using Artificial Intelligence, except that they be clearly labeled as AI Graphic Arts Products in the captions, or they are sufficiently cartoon like that no reasonable person could mistake the AI creation for an actual recorded image. This prohibition does not extend to ubiquitous “AI” clean up tools - dust/spot removal - common to current image editing software. Any significant use of AI to alter backgrounds, foregrounds, or to add/remove subject matter, is strictly prohibited, unless the image is then marked as an AI Altered Graphic Arts Product.

Content Credentials

Whensoever possible, STCC encourages its image makers to utilize equipment that includes Content Credentials (e.g., Leica Content Credentials) as established by the Content Authenticity Initiative. Leica and other manufacturers have “implemented the global Coalition for Content Provenance and Authenticity (C2PA) standard ... so that each image is captured with secure meta data” (contentauthenticity.org). Content Credentials require a secure chip be built into each camera, effectively excluding all older cameras from C2PA. C2PA compliance is not obligatory; rather, it is a current suggestion, and a future goal. Image makers should seek C2PA enabled technology each time they upgrade their kit. In ten to fifteen years, we expect C2PA compliance will become the standard of proof that images are authentic: captured, not created.

Appendix III - Explainers

Personal Protective Equipment explainer

Regarding the use of disposable (medical, latex or nitrile) gloves, there should be no exception for land-based activities, and especially not for nesting activities (relocations, nest checks, excavations). The use of non-disposable gloves brings a high risk of cross contamination, including spreading of microbial microbiomes from one nest to another during nest checks. We are aware that disposable gloves break during the digging associated with nest checks and excavations; put on replacements. The gloves cost our organization nothing (they are donated). It is far better to expend the small effort of replacing gloves than to unintentionally destroy a nest, wholly or partially, by transferring unknown contaminants into the nest chamber. Some contaminants can linger on “work” gloves. In the past, as a corroborated example, our staff and volunteers would dig into a nest on Klein Curacao one day to do a nest check, then wind up at Porto Mari digging out a nest to relocate it at Playa Porto Mari on Curacao - using the same gloves in two totally separate environments on different islands. This is how the pathogenic *Fusarium* fungi (responsible for embryonic mortality, termed Sea Turtle Egg Fusariosis), plus viruses and other potentially deleterious elements of the microbiome, can move from nest to nest at the hands of the very people who are trying to save the turtles.

Appendix IV - Image Intern

It is suggested that among the many interns STCC hosts during each calendar year, there be Image Interns (perhaps two or three 4 or 6 month internships per year, overlapping as little as possible, while providing full coverage for the role). Briefly, the duty of properly vetted Image Interns would fall into two broad categories, image capture and image organization. Image Interns would work with the Scientific, Data, Social Media, and Educational Committees, and alongside established STCC image makers, to document turtle events. Image Interns would

simultaneously be required to maintain STCC's image collection, keeping it up to date by loading images taken during the span of their internship into the primary and backup databases in a clearly organized manner, as per STCC standards.

Appendix V - Vetted STCC Image Makers

Vetted Image Makers are often, but need not necessarily be, members of the STCC Scientific Committee. Being Scientific Committee members helps to ensure that STCC's image makers understand the full import of their roles. The STCC Scientific Committee should formalize the standards for becoming a vetted image maker, to include a complete understanding of these guidelines and a portfolio review. It is suggested, so that there are plenty of qualified image makers to be called upon over the course of a year, that STCC maintain approximately 5% of the active volunteer ranks as vetted image makers. This will entail creating a training manual, a short course covering these guidelines, and a then an apprenticeship lasting several months, culminating with a portfolio review for any new STCC image makers who are new to image making (experienced photographers & videographers can simply submit a portfolio for review). Yes, we should train novices, advance their skill sets, and create a growing pool of highly qualified volunteers. Until such time as STCC is considerably better funded, it is the responsibility of the image makers to supply all their equipment. In the case of still photography, we prefer full frame (36 x 24mm) or medium format (~44 x 33mm) digital cameras, not APS-C or Micro Four Thirds cropped sensors; our images are often used at large scale for poster sized prints and lecture screens. All rules have exceptions: we often record stills in-water with OM System cameras which have tiny 6.17 x 4.55mm sensors. Eventually, it would be nice if STCC acquired proper "dive" housings for full frame cameras that are available to vetted image makers capturing in water events. All these details must be sorted out, in terms of minimum training, minimum experience, minimum equipment for still and video imagery, including drones. Drone usage will require an addition to the guidelines covering drone safety and legality; currently on Curacao, drones are not permitted in the new Seru Largu National Park.

Appendix VI - Quick Image Making Field Rules

- No Posed Images With Turtles
- No Selfies With Turtles
- No Flash
- Maintain A Safe Distance
- Do Not Interfere With Research or Rescue Activities
- Always Wear Gloves When Handling Turtles
- Never Bait, Feed, Or Manipulate Turtles For Images
- Ask When In Doubt

*Please note and understand, any time either the simple word Photo or Video, or Photographer or Videographer, is used in this document for ease of locution, that all forms of electronic image recording and recorders are intended and all image makers should be, if not utterly bound, then firmly guided, and protected, by these standards.